power base. New innovations only come when there is a fresh flow of ideas and a stronger collaboration between the trainers and students is the path for it.

One possible solution to this could be to make it mandatory for master's degree holders and PhD holders to spend at least a year in an educator's role, training not just the students but also helping upskill the rest of the trainers in academic institutions.

The debate around the quality of academia needs to be hotter. This is the only way to help provide quality educators who can help bring about the next technological disruptions through their training.

Industry, government, and academia

The facets of 5G are such that there is every possibility to create a pathbreaking framework where workplaces, educational institutions, and skilling centres can talk to each other. This conversation means that everybody involved needs to pool in their effort. It requires a holistic approach.

For the talent to take lead in not just India but the rest of the world, there needs to be a true public partnership. "A public partnership comes from the perspective of recognition and standardisation," says Ved Mani Tiwari, COO, NSDC.

A common complaint from the industry is that there is a lack of skilled talent, while the workforce complains about the refusal of the industry to make an effort to provide that skilling on the job. A better connection with the industry is the crucial step to putting an end to this chicken and egg situation. As a first step, skilling institutes need to make certifications of such a level that the industry loves to take those certified people.

The whole point of training the trainers also needs to ride on the back of the industry. The industry-academia integration needs to take a stronger and more supportive approach. Providing the institutes with the necessary equipment, which otherwise takes ages to reach them as they pass through multiple levels of authorisations and tenders, can be a helpful step.

As for academia, it needs to have a more open approach toward upskilling the existing workforce in the industry. A big part of why upskilling seems tedious to the workforce is the number of efforts they waste in learning from scratch, something that they might not necessarily require.

Modules and courses have to be framed in a less conservative and more flexible way. For instance, counting a certain number of years of work experience as credits. With these credits, they may skip the initial foundational education and move on to the meat of the curriculum in the second or third year of college. Offering apprenticeship modes (ranging from a few weeks to a few months) can be another way to smoothly upskill/reskill the workforce.

This is how true integration and balance between academia and industry can take place.

A multi-faceted approach

IoT, drones, Industry 4.0—all these new technologies need assistance from the telecom sector to reach their true potential. Although the opportunities are riled up, the challenges to fairly skill/upskill/reskill the workforce need to be overcome to truly achieve the target.

A proper partnership by various stakeholders in the economy is the need of the hour. Skilling needs to be not just multidisciplinary but also multi-ministerial. After all, becoming a global power in the technology manufacturing space is a team effort. It is high time we treat it like one. EFY

This article, based on panel discussions hosted by Telecom Sector Skill Council during the Annual Telecom Report Release, has been transcribed and curated by EFY Business Journalist Siddha Dhar.

Speakers

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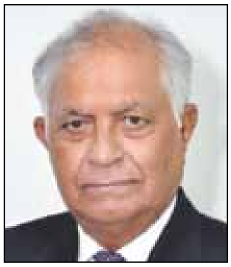
Rehman Khan Suri, Professor, DSEU



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